



“Stop the unattainable ideal for an ordinary me!” fostering parasocial relationships with social media influencers: The role of self-discrepancy

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ABSTRACT

The unprecedented interactivity of social media has empowered social media influencers to develop close relationships with their followers, and such relationships carry important marketing implications for social media influencers and brands. The present study examines the antecedents and outcomes of followers' parasocial relationships with social media influencers. Drawing upon the theoretical lens of parasocial interaction theory, influence framework, and attribution framework, the study proposes and empirically tests the effects of social media influencers' influence attempts on parasocial relationships, and the subsequent downstream outcomes of perceived endorser motives and consumer purchase intentions. Using a survey-based approach, the study collected 361 usable responses, and data were analyzed using partial least squares structural equation modeling. The study found that (1) influence attempts (i.e., attractiveness, prestige, and expertise) positively influence parasocial relationships, whereas (2) parasocial relationships negatively influence perceived endorser motive (self-serving), which in turn (3) reduces purchase intention, and (4) self-discrepancy moderates the relationships between influence attempts and parasocial relationships. Two post-hoc exploratory analyses uncover the impacts of number of followers and gender in the proposed relationships. Theoretical and practical implications are discussed.

1. Introduction

The rise of social media has opened a plethora of new marketing opportunities, including influencer marketing, which involves promotion of products and services by individuals who hold sway over other consumers (Ge & Gretzel, 2018). In the present study, social media influencers refer to individuals who have gained popularity due to their social media presence and content, such as bloggers, YouTubers, and Instagram influencers. Heralded as the new frontier of influencer marketing, social media influencers have started to secure their places in the market and are even deemed more effective in product/brand endorsement than the traditional celebrities (Jin, Muqaddam, & Ryu, 2019). A recent survey by Twitter revealed that 40% of platform users were enticed into purchasing a product due to Tweets from influencers (Influencer Marketing Hub, 2020). Likewise, Google statistics indicate that 60% of YouTube subscribers tend to follow purchase advice given by their favorite influencers (Influencer Marketing Hub, 2020). These positive implications have resulted in substantial growth in

endorsements, whereby brands are currently paying influencers about \$25, \$20, and \$10 for every 1000 followers on Facebook, YouTube, and Instagram and Snapchat, respectively (Johnson, 2020).

In today's marketplace flooded by advertisements and influencer endorsements, consumers have become more alert to the motives behind the persuasive attempts of marketers. The importance of motive inference has been made apparent in prior business literature, where authors of extant studies demonstrate that promotions by firms perceived to be public-serving instead of self-serving are more likely to generate purchase intent (Lee, Haley, & Yang, 2013; Reinhard, Messner, & Sporer, 2006). Often, consumers' perception and motive inference towards social media influencers are imperiled when they partner with brands for endorsement (Audrezet, De Kerviler, & Moulard, 2020; Pöyry, Pelkonen, Naumanen, & Laaksonen, 2019). A recent research report published by Roth Capital Partners indicates that one-third of surveyed Millennials do not believe that social media influencers have their best interests in mind (Kirkpatrick, 2017). As consumers are active recipients of endorsement content, they seek to evaluate the ulterior motives of

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endorsers (Shan, Chen, & Lin, 2019). It has been suggested that, when consumers perceive social media influencers' brand endorsements as publicity stunts motivated by financial gains, the endorsement effectiveness decreases (e.g., purchase intention declines), posing a threat to the endorsing brand as well as the influencer (Shan et al., 2019). Therefore, we contend that consumers' attribution of the motives is the cornerstone for building a successful influencer marketing strategy.

While being relevant and insightful, prior studies on this topic are confined to treating motive inference towards companies or endorsers as the determinant of product evaluation (Lee et al., 2013; Shan et al., 2019). There is a paucity of studies that tap into the management of motive inference, especially in the influencer marketing context. We address this gap by applying the lens of parasocial relationship theory (Horton & Wohl, 1956; Labrecque, 2014) to the existing studies on influencers' influence attempts (Audrezet et al., 2020; Ki & Kim, 2019) and our survey data to understand the mechanism through which the perception of endorser motive as self-serving can be mitigated. Our rationale is supported by available evidence indicating that consumers are more likely to trust influencers with whom they have developed parasocial relationships (i.e., one-sided relationships that individuals form with mediated personas), and tend to withhold their critical evaluation towards influencers' sponsored commercial activities (Audrezet et al., 2020; Moraes, Gountas, Gountas, & Sharma, 2019).

Apart from investigating the implications of parasocial relationships, there is a need to identify the mechanisms by which celebrity–fan relationships can be reinforced (Aw & Labrecque, 2020). Content posted by social media influencers provides a platform for influencer–fan interactions that may give rise to parasocial relationships (Aw & Labrecque, 2020; Wellman, Stoldt, Tully, & Ekdale, 2020). However, compared to the extensively tested source effects (i.e., influencer traits), the influence attempts (i.e., content) as a promotional strategy by social media influencers have been largely overlooked in extant studies. As a result, it remains largely unknown how social media influencers' influence attempts can be managed to bolster parasocial relationships. Under these premises, we seek to understand the role of parasocial relationships in relation to perceived endorser motive, and the principal traits of social media influencers' content that fosters parasocial relationships.

The concept of self-discrepancy (i.e., discrepancy between actual and ideal selves) is indispensable in the social comparison process, as it inevitably occurs when one is exposed to influencer marketing (Jin et al., 2019). To the best of authors' knowledge, there is no previously published research examining the role of self-discrepancy in relation to social media influencers' influence attempts. To address this gap, we aim to examine the moderating role of self-discrepancy to provide a more nuanced understanding of the boundary conditions embedded in the relationship between influence attempts and parasocial relationships, as consumers' meaning appropriation from influencers' influence attempts is subjected to the appraisal of self-concept (i.e., self-discrepancy) (Malär, Herzog, Krohmer, Hoyer, & Kähr, 2018).

The present study advances extant knowledge on two hitherto overlooked topics in the influencer endorsement literature, namely parasocial relationships and perceived endorser motives. Through a series of main and post-hoc analyses, it contributes to the understanding of the mechanisms through which social media influencers' influence attempts (i.e., attractiveness, prestige, and expertise) can foster parasocial relationships, which in turn determine consumers' perceptions of endorser motives and purchase intentions. Additionally, we offer in-depth insights into the aforementioned relationships by shedding light on the moderating role of self-discrepancy and gender. Based on our findings, we offer recommendations to brand marketers and social media influencers regarding endorser selection as well as impression/relationship management in order to optimize brand endorsement effectiveness.

2. Conceptual development

2.1. Social media influencers

Most of the existing research on influencer endorsement either in the traditional celebrity or social media context has been limited to the investigation of source effects (source credibility and attractiveness), product/brand–endorser match-up, and endorsement outcomes (e.g., brand attitude, brand trust, purchase intention) (Bergkvist & Zhou, 2016; Jin et al., 2019; Schimmelpfennig & Hunt, 2020; Weismueller, Harrigan, Wang, & Soutar, 2020). These theoretical perspectives have been critiqued for being overly simplistic and incapable of capturing the complexity of influencer–consumer interactions (Moraes et al., 2019). These issues have prompted authors of recent studies to advocated for the adoption of the influencer–follower emotional attachment lens, focusing specifically on the role of pseudo-relationships (i.e., parasocial relationships) in understanding endorsement effectiveness, which is highly relevant in the realm of social media yet remains under-researched (Aw & Labrecque, 2020; Moraes et al., 2019). The aforementioned gap has motivated the present study, the aim of which is to examine the potential antecedents and outcomes of parasocial relationships in the social media influencer context. Moreover, influencers' impression management has received scant attention in the literature. One prominent aspect of impression management in relation to influencer endorsement is the endorser motive inference by consumers (Carlson, Donovan, Deitz, Bauer, & Lala, 2020; Shan et al., 2019). This strand of research has revealed that self-serving motives evoke distrust and induce negative consumer evaluations towards endorsers and the related endorsement. Unfortunately, it remains unknown how social media influencers can strategically choreograph consumers' motive attribution for themselves, given that they are constantly under pressure to balance the expectations of their followers to be authentic and benevolent, while being economically profitable for their brand partners. This research gap represents a fruitful yet insufficiently explored research area, as consumers' perceptions of endorser motives can pose a great threat to the social media influencers' persuasiveness and endorsement effectiveness (Audrezet et al., 2020; Shan et al., 2019; van Driel & Dumitrica, 2020).

2.2. Theoretical foundation

Authors of recent influencer endorsement studies concur that no singular theory is adequate for explaining the effectiveness of influencer endorsements (Aw & Labrecque, 2020; Schimmelpfennig & Hunt, 2020). To overcome this issue, we integrate the influence framework (Scheer & Stern, 1992) and attribution framework (Kapitan & Silvera, 2016) to (i) elucidate how social media influencers' influence attempts foster parasocial relationships, and (ii) identify the downstream implications of parasocial relationships (i.e., perceived endorser motives and consumers' purchase intentions). The influence framework pioneered by Scheer and Stern (1992) highlights the power dynamic in the influencer marketing context, in which social media influencers are in control of power resources and leverage them trigger desired attitudinal and behavioral responses in their followers. In the present study, the power resources encompass attractiveness, prestige, and expertise (Ki & Kim, 2019; Scheer & Stern, 1992) as influencers' primary marketing tools, which they promote through their social media content. These influence attempts (i.e., attractiveness, prestige, and expertise) not only determine the persuasiveness of communication but also the perceived social relationships between the information source and the receiver (Ismagilova, Slade, Rana, & Dwivedi, 2019; Kapitan & Silvera, 2016). Moreover, by synthesizing the critical theoretical elements of meaning transfer, attribution, source effect, and information processing, the attribution framework allows identification of the linkages between source factors and correspondence bias (Fiske & Taylor, 1991; Kapitan & Silvera, 2016). The theory contends that people tend to make

correspondence bias in their attributional processing when they socially identify with the interacting entities (i.e., influencer endorsers) that manifest positive source characteristics, motivating consumers to adopt internal/dispositional attribution and to believe that the influencer endorsers truly like the products they are promoting while disregarding the fact that they are being paid and sponsored (Kapitan & Silvera, 2016; Kelman, 1961). Such attributions and correspondent inferences endow unquestioned credibility to the influencer endorsers' motives, which underlies the success of endorsement marketing.

2.3. Parasocial relationships

Parasocial relationships denote one-sided relationships that a person develops with mediated personas, including social media influencers (Horton & Wohl, 1956). These relationships create an illusion of real and intense interpersonal connections, encompassing the elements of friendship and understanding (Chung & Cho, 2017; Horton & Wohl, 1956). Recently, the role of parasocial relationships has been extended beyond the traditional mass media such as television and radio to include the online environment (Labrecque, 2014). The social media environment provides influencers and fans a more conducive platform for fostering interactions and connections of an unprecedented intensity. Influencers can interact with consumers instantly through social media and can effortlessly share their everyday lives from a first-person perspective. As a result, despite not knowing influencers in person, consumers tend to develop intense intimacy and psychological connections with them (Schnickel, 1985).

The concept of parasocial relationships has long been a subject of academic research, but the focus has recently shifted from traditional celebrities to social media influencers. Findings yielded by these investigations indicate that social media interactions foster parasocial relationships with celebrities (Chung & Cho, 2017). For instance, celebrities are able to reduce interpersonal uncertainty and engender more intense parasocial relationships through higher posting frequency (Ledbetter & Redd, 2016). Thus far, researchers tended to examine parasocial relationships through the lens of source characteristics model. These studies have identified influencers' attractiveness and credibility as salient predictors of parasocial relationships, suggesting that influencers who are perceived as good-looking and trustworthy can evoke intense illusory attachment in their fans (Gong & Li, 2017; Sakib, Zolfagharian, & Yazdanparast, 2020; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). Another major stream of research relates to the impacts of parasocial relationships on influencer- and brand-related outcomes. Authors of prior studies in this domain posit that consumer-endorser relationships are a powerful indicator of endorsement effectiveness as well as influencers' ability to persuade consumers (Aw & Labrecque, 2020; Carlson et al., 2020; Wellman et al., 2020). For example, parasocial relationships have been found to increase the trustworthiness of celebrities endorsing the brand, which would in turn strengthen followers' intention to purchase (Chung & Cho, 2017; Jin & Ryu, 2020; Reinikainen, Munnukka, Maity, & Luoma-aho, 2020; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020).

Synthesizing the literature reviewed above, it can be concluded that social media influencer research has offered ample evidence indicating that influencer characteristics are crucial in fostering parasocial relationships, which can yield benefits to influencers and their endorsing brands. However, despite recognizing influencers' social media content as the key to effective communication and formation of influencer-follower relationships, a holistic understanding of its role as a source of influence attempts is lacking (Martínez-López, Anaya-Sánchez, Fernández Giordano, & Lopez-Lopez, 2020). Authors of previous studies in this field concur that content posted by influencers can trigger changes in consumers' perceptions and behavior towards influencers as well as their endorsing brands (Casaló, Flavián, & Ibáñez-Sánchez, 2020; Ki & Kim, 2019). Hence, we seek to identify the effect of social media influencers' content characteristics as influence attempts in fostering parasocial relationships in order to offer a more manageable strategy for

social media influencers that is complementary to the traditional source effects. In addition, although past research has contended that the halo effect may cloud consumers' perceptions and render them less critical of paid commercial and promotional activities by their favorite celebrities (Moraes et al., 2019), the effect that parasocial relationships may exert on perceived influencer endorser motives has never been investigated, presenting a gap that is addressed in the present study.

2.4. Fostering parasocial relationships through influence attempts

We leveraged on the general social media marketing literature to determine the types of influence attempts to be included in our research model. Successful social media marketing entails strategically crafted social media content targeting a specific consumer segment (Dolan, Conduit, Frethey-Bentham, Fahy, & Goodman, 2019; Swani, Milne, Brown, Assaf, & Donthu, 2017). In that respect, social media content conveys functional and hedonic appeals that address specific needs of consumers (Swani et al., 2017). Here, the term "functional" refers to the informativeness or expertise aspects of the content, while "hedonic" encapsulates affective and transformational components (Dolan et al., 2019; Tafesse & Wein, 2018). According to these definitions, social media content appeals largely conform to the core postulates of the source effect model frequently adopted in the influencer literature. For example, functional appeals via social media content are congruent with the source expertise attribute (to address need for information), while hedonic appeals—comprising of sensory qualities (e.g., aesthetically appealing) and emotional/resonance cues (e.g., ego and social messages)—reflect the concepts of source attractiveness and prestige, respectively (Kim & Yang, 2017). Notably, findings reported in recent social media influencer literature validate the content attributes of attractiveness, prestige, and expertise as the three most common influence attempts employed by influencers in their interactions with followers (Ki, Cuevas, Chong, & Lim, 2020; Ki & Kim, 2019), further justifying the inclusion of these influence attempts in the present study.

Interpersonal theories postulate that communication is pivotal to the development of interpersonal relationships, and the same principle applies to the formation of parasocial relationships (Altman & Taylor, 1973; Rubin & McHugh, 1987), even in the new media context. As evidenced by Labrecque (2014), parasocial interactions can be fostered through social media message content cues (i.e., perceived interactivity and openness in communication). According to the theory of parasocial interactions, parasocial relationships represent an outcome of a need or motivational state (e.g., expressive and affiliation needs) (Auer, 1992), and these needs are gratified through communication with the media/media figure (Rubin & McHugh, 1987). Followers tend to gravitate towards intimate relationships with media figures if their needs are fulfilled (Thomson, 2006). Media personalities, including social media influencers, deliberately utilize influence attempts (i.e., social media content) to engender the feeling of closeness and connectedness (Feraud, Grzeslo, Orme, & LaGroue, 2018; Yuksel & Labrecque, 2016). The principal traits of these influence attempts serve as meaning cues that consumers appropriate for their need fulfillment, and determine emotional bonding with social media influencers (Ki et al., 2020). Drawing upon the social psychology literature, desired attributes such as attractiveness, prestige, and expertise are central to interpersonal relationship-related judgments (Montoya & Horton, 2014). Therefore, we posit that these content-driven attributes may contribute to the development of parasocial relationships that are typically seen as similar to interpersonal social relationships.

In the present study, attractiveness refers to the degree to which one perceives a social media influencer's social media content as visually or aesthetically appealing (Patzer, 1983). The notion of attractiveness stereotypes is well-established in the social psychology literature, suggesting that exposure to or interaction with attractive targets tends to elicit positive emotions and a desire to establish a close relationship (Lemay Jr, Clark, & Greenberg, 2010). Likewise, previous studies

grounded in the source attractiveness model demonstrated a link between source attractiveness and parasocial relationships, suggesting that when influencers are perceived as physically or socially attractive, consumers tend to devote more attention to and engage more intensively with the influencers, thereby nurturing parasocial relationships (Gong & Li, 2017; Lee & Watkins, 2016; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). Therefore, as social media content posted by influencers represents an indispensable bridge that connects influencers and consumers, it cultivates influencer-fan relationships. Drawing on the social identity theory (Brewer, 1991), we posit that consumers are likely to identify with influencers who generate attractive content to satisfy their self-definitional needs, as indicated in the following hypothesis:

H1: Attractiveness is positively related to parasocial relationships.

In line with the arguments put forth by Ki and Kim (2019), the definition of prestige adopted in the present study refers to the extent a social media influencer's social media content manifests the characteristics of high status. Moreover, according to the extant brand literature, consumers are motivated to identify with prestigious brands as a means to achieve favorable psychological states, such as self-enhancement (Lam, Ahearne, Mullins, Hayati, & Schillewaert, 2013). In a similar vein, sense of prestige conveyed through content posted by social media influencers leads to a more favorable evaluation by consumers (Ki & Kim, 2019). As postulated by the social identity theory, when defining their self-identity, people are driven by a desire for self-enhancement (Kunda, 1999). They would therefore identify with influencers who present a prestigious identity and image to immerse themselves in their reflected glory as a way of enhancing their self-esteem (Hu, Min, Han, & Liu, 2020). Notably, pursuing relationships with prestigious others can improve a person's perception of own social status, due to which prestige is a significant cue for interpersonal attraction (Lo, 2008). In line with these arguments, we posit that prestige as an influence attempt can foster parasocial relationships between social media influencers and followers, as indicated below:

H2: Prestige is positively related to parasocial relationships.

Expertise refers to social media influencers' content attributes that imply greater knowledge and/or experience in certain aspects than in others (McQuarrie, Miller, & Phillips, 2013). Expertise is recognized as a vital element in the domains of interpersonal interaction and attraction (Xiang, Zheng, Lee, & Zhao, 2016). For instance, it has been shown in the social commerce context that users tend to interact and form parasocial relationships with other users who are believed to possess considerable knowledge of brands and products. Similarly, extant celebrity endorsement literature indicates that celebrities that are perceived as experts in certain domains are able to induce positive attitudes in and form parasocial relationships with consumers (Sakib et al., 2020; Yuan, Kim, & Kim, 2016). Accordingly, we posit that social media influencers' attempts to convey expertise can shape their perceived importance for consumers' subjective social experience, which would entice more intense emulation as well as interaction, and would eventually result in favorable relational outcomes, such as the development of parasocial relationships.

H3: Expertise is positively related to parasocial relationships.

2.5. Parasocial relationships and perceived endorser motives

The attribution framework offers a theoretical perspective for examining the cognitive processes involved in the formation of causal inferences for human behavior (Kapitan & Silvera, 2016; Kelley, 1967). In the influencer endorsement context, consumers draw causal inferences from endorsers' behaviors to determine whether their motives are altruistic or self-serving (Shan et al., 2019). Consequently, if a social

media influencer is believed to endorse a brand primarily for personal benefits, such as financial compensation, enhanced image, and fame, these would be deemed self-serving motives (Shan et al., 2019). A common source of information that consumers draw upon in making such attributions is the relationship they have established with influencer endorsers (Um, 2013). Authors of extant studies have demonstrated that consumers that have developed a more intense identification or parasocial relationship with the influencer endorser tend to arrive at correspondent inferences that an influencer endorser truly likes the endorsed product, rather than promoting it for personal gains, and are thus more likely to adopt favorable attitude toward that product (Farivar, Wang, & Yuan, 2020; Hwang & Zhang, 2018). This biased evaluation is further supported by the amalgamation of parasocial relationship theory and the entertainment overcoming resistance model (Moyer-Gusé, 2008) which put forth the notion that parasocial relationships with a media figure can mitigate reactance and counter-arguments towards persuasive attempts, and ultimately trigger greater compliance (Tukachinsky, Walter, & Saucier, 2020). In sum, owing to the parasocial relationships they form with social media influencers, consumers are unlikely to perceive their motives as self-serving.

H4: Parasocial relationships are negatively related to perceived self-serving motives.

2.6. Perceived endorser motives and purchase intention

Influencer marketing strategies can be understood as persuasion attempts by persons with a considerable clout at changing and molding consumers' attitudes and behaviors towards a product or a brand. When exposed to endorsing advertisements, consumers tend to question the motives behind the influencer's decision to promote a product or a brand; hence, the effectiveness of the endorsement message or advertisement depends on whether consumers deem these motives to be self-serving or altruistic (Shan et al., 2019). In other words, social media influencers that are perceived as self-serving endorsers would induce distrust in the advertising message, which would ultimately trigger negative response towards the endorsement deal (e.g., reduced credibility, persuasiveness, and purchase intention) (Lee et al., 2013; Reinhard et al., 2006).

H5: Motives that are perceived as self-serving are negatively related to consumers' purchase intention.

2.7. Moderating role of Self-discrepancy

The self-discrepancy theory posits that people are driven to achieve the state in which their self-concept aligns with personally relevant self-guides (Higgins, 1989). The theory is based on the premise that people have multiple selves (e.g., actual self and ideal self), whereby any discrepancies among these selves would result in discomfort. According to Noble, Haytko, and Phillips (2009), to diminish such discrepancy and alleviate discomfort, individuals engage in certain behaviors such as consumption. In the influencer context, Jin et al. (2019) contended that people who are at higher positions and/or possess desired qualities, such as celebrities or social media influencers, induce a sense of self-discrepancy in others. The notion of "basking in the reflected glory" suggests that consumers appropriate the admired attributes of a relationship partner that signal their ideal self (Cialdini et al., 1976). Social media influencers' star power derives from their digital content as a key medium for their identity creation and dissemination, as consumers tend to appropriate meaning encapsulated in the content (Escalas & Bettman, 2017). For instance, Ki and Kim (2019) found that influence attempts (i.e., content) by social media influencers increase consumers' desire to mimic their attitudes and behaviors. When consumers are exposed to influence attempts by social media influencers, they are inevitably involved in social comparisons.

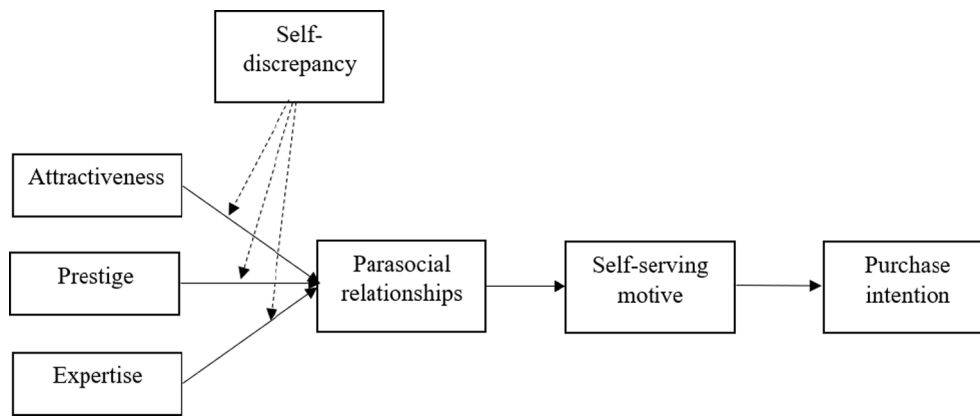


Fig. 1. Research model.

However, we argue that how meanings and cues from the influence attempts are appropriated is unlikely to be uniform across followers, as it is subjected to followers' self-concept appraisal. According to [Malär et al. \(2018\)](#), whether an individual assimilates or disapproves of the attributes conveyed by the object of upward social comparison (i.e., social media influencer) is determined by self-discrepancy. The information-processing literature holds that information is more likely to be assimilated by consumers and is more persuasive when it fits consumers' self-discrepancy-related goal, which is to narrow the gap between their actual and ideal self ([Dijkstra, Schakenraad, Menninga, Buunk, & Siero, 2009](#)). People with a high degree of self-discrepancy tend to emulate their favorite celebrities as a way of shifting their actual self toward their ideal self, and are thus more empathetic toward their favorite celebrities ([Derrick, Gabriel, & Tippin, 2008](#)). Studies have shown that communication from media figures exerts stronger positive effect on interpersonally affiliative individuals, as manifested in high degree of self-discrepancy ([Lee & Jang, 2013](#); [Lee & Oh, 2012](#)). As a result, we posit that consumers with high self-discrepancy are more likely to assimilate and resonate with the influence attempts (i.e., attractiveness, prestige, and expertise), and form affirming parasocial relationships with social media influencers in order to close the self-discrepancy gap. Conversely, the impacts of influence attempts on parasocial relationships may be relatively weak for consumers with low self-discrepancy as they are less susceptible to external influence ([Pentina, Taylor, & Voelker, 2009](#)). Hence, we hypothesize the following:

H6: Self-discrepancy moderates the link between attractiveness and parasocial relationships, which is stronger for those exhibiting a high degree of self-discrepancy.

H7: Self-discrepancy moderates the link between prestige and parasocial relationships, which is stronger for those exhibiting a high degree of self-discrepancy.

H8: Self-discrepancy moderates the link between expertise and parasocial relationships, which is stronger for those exhibiting a high degree of self-discrepancy.

The proposed research model is illustrated in [Fig. 1](#).

3. Methodology

3.1. Data collection and sample characteristics

Given that the sampling frame of social media users who followed social media influencers is inaccessible, we adopted the purposive sampling technique which deemed appropriate in condition where only a limited population of people possesses the required information ([Sekaran & Bougie, 2016](#)). The questionnaire was administered online through personal contacts and sharing survey link on different social

media platforms (e.g., Facebook and Instagram), which deemed thematically best suited to the study context. A screening question was presented on the first page asking respondents to indicate one of their favorite social media influencers, who they have followed on social media. Those who failed the screening criteria were discontinued from participating, and debriefed. We also explicated a brief definition of social media influencers to retrieve more accurate responses from the respondents. The social media influencer's name indicated was embedded in the remainder of the questionnaire. After removing straight-lining responses and those who did not address the defined social media influencers, 361 usable responses were collected.

Majority of the respondents were female (65.1%) and students (68.1%). Most of them (77.3%) were in the age categories between 18 and 25 years old. In addition, the majority of respondents were Caucasian (54.3%), followed by Asian (24.8%), Hispanics (6.9%) and others. Half of the respondents (51.0%) indicated Instagram as their most used social media platform, followed by YouTube (36.6%), and Facebook (6.1%). Examples of frequently mentioned social media influencers by the respondents were PewDiePie, Chiara Ferragni, Jenna Marbles, and Shane Dawson, among others.

3.2. Measures

We adapted well-established and validated measures from the literature (see [Table A1](#)). The scales for influence attempts (i.e., attractiveness, prestige, and expertise) and purchase intention were adapted from [Ki and Kim \(2019\)](#). The scales for parasocial relationships were adapted from [Chung and Cho \(2017\)](#). [Rifon, Choi, Trimble, and Li \(2004\)](#) scales were adapted to assess perceived self-serving motive. The actual-self and ideal-self concepts were measured using [Sirgy et al. \(1997\)](#) scales. Self-discrepancy score was calculated by subtracting the actual-self score from the ideal-self score. All items were measured with seven-point Likert scales, anchored by "1 = strongly disagree" and "7 = strongly agree". Two researchers independently reviewed the measures to ensure absence of ambiguity in comprehending the questionnaire items. Subsequently, the questionnaire was pilot-tested with forty respondents. Cronbach's α for all variables ranged from 0.74 to 0.95, indicating satisfactory internal consistency ([Hair, Black, Babin, Anderson, & Tatham, 2006](#)).

4. Data analysis

4.1. Common method bias

In order to minimize the threat of common method bias arises in cross-sectional design study, procedural and statistical remedies were undertaken ([Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, & Podsakoff, 2003](#)). In terms of procedural remedy, respondents were informed there was no right or

Table 1

Construct reliability and validity, discriminant validity.

Construct	CR	AVE	Attractiveness	Purchase intention	Parasocial relationships	Prestige	Expertise	Self-serving motive
Attractiveness	0.950	0.862	0.929					
Purchase intention	0.937	0.831	0.458	0.912				
Parasocial relationships	0.922	0.568	0.397	0.484	0.754			
Prestige	0.920	0.792	0.628	0.456	0.372	0.890		
Expertise	0.935	0.828	0.515	0.367	0.367	0.596	0.910	
Self-serving motive	0.788	0.562	−0.437	−0.626	−0.630	−0.434	−0.472	0.749

Notes: Diagonal elements present the square root of the AVE (in bold).

wrong answers, and their honest answers matter the most. Also, they were assured of anonymity (Podsakoff et al., 2003). With regards to statistical remedy, we performed the Harman's single-factor test. The result showed that the first factor explained 35% of the total variance, below the recommended 50% threshold. We further employed the full collinearity test, and found that the VIF values ranged from 1.067 to 2.193, which were below the threshold level of 3.3, thus confirming that common method bias is not a significant threat in the present study (Kock, 2015).

Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modelling (PLS-SEM)

PLS-SEM was employed to test the proposed research model for several reasons. First, PLS-SEM is appropriate when the aim of the study is to predict a key endogenous construct (i.e. purchase intention) (Hair, Risher, Sarstedt, & Ringle, 2019). Second, PLS-SEM is superior in handling complex structural models as characterized by the present study, of which the research model involves many latent constructs, indicators, and complex relationships (e.g., moderation) (Hair et al., 2019). Third, PLS-SEM is less restrictive with sample size, measurement scales, and data distribution assumptions.

4.2. Measurement model

Four criteria were assessed in the evaluation of measurement model. First, as shown in Table 1, all constructs exhibited composite reliability greater than 0.7, indicating strong internal consistency (Hair, Hult, Ringle, & Sarstedt, 2017). Second, the convergent validity was examined in terms of factor loadings and average variance extracted (AVE). As exhibited in Table 1, all items showed factor loadings above 0.7 except three items from perceived self-serving motive, which were removed. AVE values of all constructs were above the 0.5 threshold, suggesting that all items accounted for most of the variance of their respective constructs (Hair et al., 2017). Discriminant validity was examined by comparing inter-construct correlations with the square roots of AVE for each construct. As shown in Table 1, square root of AVE for each construct exceeded the respective inter-construct correlations, indicating the establishment of discriminant validity (Fornell & Larcker, 1981).

4.3. Structural model

Before examining the structural relationships, we examined multicollinearity issue which potentially bias the regression results. The result indicated that the highest VIF value was 1.981, well below the recommended 3.0 threshold (Hair et al., 2019). Our analysis of the structural model found R^2 of 0.448, suggesting 44.8% of variance in purchase intention was explained by the model. In addition, the model exhibited satisfactory predictive relevance, with Q^2 value greater than zero (0.32) (Fornell & Cha, 1994).

The study supports the direct effect of influence attempts, namely attractiveness ($\beta = 0.228$, $p < .05$), prestige ($\beta = 0.124$, $p < .05$), and expertise ($\beta = 0.176$, $p < .05$) on parasocial relationships. Parasocial relationships has a significant negative effect on perceived self-serving motive ($\beta = -0.630$, $p < .05$). Lastly, perceived self-serving motive

Table 2

Hypothesis testing for direct effects and moderation.

Hypothesis	Relationship	Std. Beta	t-value	Decision
H1	Attractiveness → Parasocial relationship	0.228**	3.534	Supported
H2	Prestige → Parasocial relationship	0.124*	1.965	Supported
H3	Expertise → Parasocial relationship	0.176**	2.611	Supported
H4	Parasocial relationship → Self-serving motive	−0.630**	17.559	Supported
H5	Self-serving motive → Purchase intention	−0.626**	17.654	Supported
H6	Self-discrepancy*Attractiveness → Parasocial relationship	−0.098*	1.712	Unsupported
H7	Self-discrepancy*Prestige → Parasocial relationship	−0.111*	1.619	Unsupported
H8	Self-discrepancy*Expertise → Parasocial relationship	0.052 ^{n.s.}	0.786	Unsupported

Note: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, n.s. = not significant.

negatively influences purchase intention ($\beta = -0.626$, $p < .05$). Hence, H1 to H5 were supported (See Table 2).

With respect to the moderation, we found significant moderating effects of self-discrepancy in the links between attractiveness ($\beta = -0.098$, $p < .05$), prestige ($\beta = -0.111$, $p < .05$), and parasocial relationships. Subsequently, we created an interaction plot to better interpret the nature of moderation detected. As shown in Figs. 2 and 3, the links between influence attempts (i.e., attractiveness and prestige) and parasocial relationships are stronger when the self-discrepancy is low. Although these effects were significant, they contradict to our earlier hypotheses, thus H6 to H8 were unsupported.

4.4. Post-hoc analysis: Exploring the role of the number of followers

Signaling theory contends that consumers seek out cues/signals from a brand to mitigate the information asymmetry (Spence, 1973), which is particularly pronounced in the social media environment where information abounds. In this respect, consumers rely on easily interpretable metrics such as number of views and likes to draw inferences regarding the quality of online content, product/services, and their providers. As the number of followers is one of the distinctive metrics that characterize a social media account (Hill, Troshani, & Chandrasekar, 2017), it signifies social media influencers' popularity and potential market reach (De Veirman, Cauberghe, & Hudders, 2017; Weismueller et al., 2020). Available evidence suggests that social media influencers with a high number of followers are generally seen as more socially desirable in terms of source attractiveness and credibility (De Veirman et al., 2017; Jin & Phua, 2014), and these perceived characteristics are transferable to the products they endorse or review. Correspondingly, Weismueller et al. (2020) recently articulated that social media influencers with a high number of followers can generate effective marketing implications, such as evoking consumers' purchase intention.

Based on the above discussion, in the present study, we test the impact of number of followers on parasocial relationships, perception of

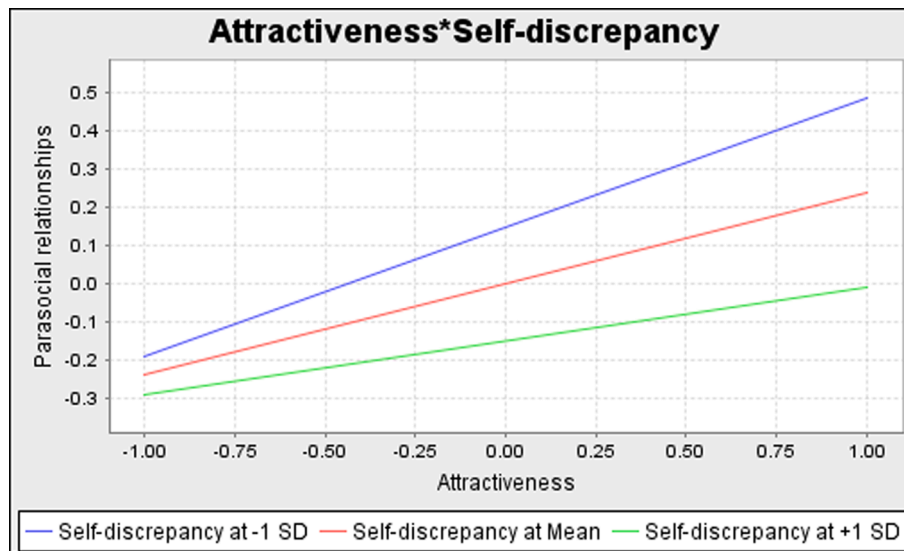


Fig. 2. Moderating effect of self-discrepancy in the relationship between attractiveness and parasocial relationships.

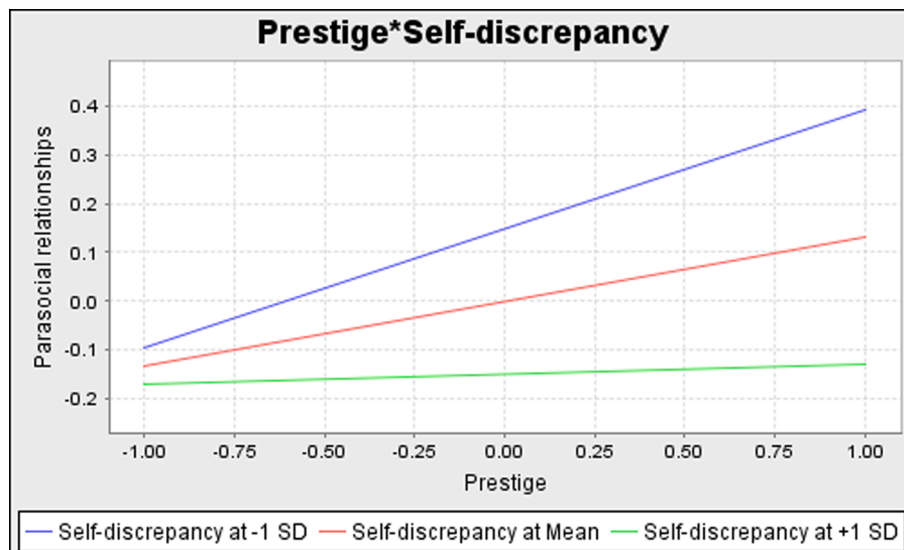


Fig. 3. Moderating effect of self-discrepancy in the relationship between prestige and parasocial relationships.

influencer motives as self-serving, and consumers' purchase intentions. To this end, the number of followers was extracted from the Instagram accounts of social media influencers mentioned by our respondents. Following the approach taken by Benitez, Henseler, Castillo, and Schubert (2020), the number of followers was modeled as a single-indicator construct after applying natural logarithm due to the skewed distribution. The results showed that number of followers has a

significant negative effect on parasocial relationships ($\beta = -0.097, p < .05$) but not the perception of influencer motives as self-serving ($\beta = 0.004, p > .05$) or consumers' purchase intention ($\beta = 0.005, p > .05$).

Table 3

Results of partial invariance measurement testing.

Constructs	Configural invariance	Compositional invariance (Correlation = 1)		Equal mean		Equal variances		FMI
		C = 1	5% quantile	Dif	CI	Dif.	CI	
ATTR	Yes	1.000	0.999	0.479	[−0.230; 0.253]	−0.481	[−0.435; 0.420]	No
PRES	Yes	0.997	0.996	0.249	[−0.236; 0.231]	−0.327	[−0.326; 0.334]	No
EXP	Yes	1.000	0.997	0.110	[−0.233; 0.253]	−0.387	[−0.431; 0.393]	Yes
PR	Yes	0.997	0.997	−0.066	[−0.266; 0.245]	−0.120	[−0.348; 0.338]	Yes
SSM	Yes	0.998	0.988	−0.286	[−0.256; 0.233]	−0.540	[−0.384; 0.388]	No
INT	Yes	1.000	0.999	0.421	[−0.229; 0.237]	−0.542	[−0.371; 0.342]	No

Notes: CI = Confidence Interval; Dif = Differences; FMI = Full measurement invariance, ATTR = Attractiveness, PRES = Prestige, EXP = Expertise, PR = Parasocial relationships, SSM = Self-serving motive, INT = Purchase intention.

Table 4
Result of PLS-MGA for gender.

Hypothesis	Relationships	Path coefficient (Male)	Path coefficient (Female)	CI's (Bias corrected) Male	CI's (Bias corrected) Female	Path coefficient differences
H1	ATTR → PR	0.285	0.291	0.140; 0.432	0.061; 0.530	−0.006
H2	PRES → PR	0.320	0.009	0.167; 0.459	−0.234; 0.185	0.311*
H3	EXP → PR	0.126	0.100	−0.048; 0.291	−0.117; 0.318	0.027
H4	PR → SSM	−0.731	−0.648	−0.806; −0.632	−0.716; −0.544	−0.083
H5	SSM → INT	−0.720	−0.494	−0.787; −0.631	−0.597; −0.357	−0.226**
Post-hoc	NOF → PR	−0.153	−0.117	−0.296; −0.009	−0.282; 0.081	−0.036
Post-hoc	NOF → SSM	−0.061	−0.030	−0.179; 0.049	−0.155; 0.105	−0.031
Post-hoc	NOF → INT	−0.001	0.059	−0.122; 0.125	−0.094; 0.227	−0.059

Notes: $p < 0.01^{**}$, $p < 0.05^{*}$, n.s. = not significant, ATTR = Attractiveness, PRES = Prestige, EXP = Expertise, PR = Parasocial relationships, SSM = Self-serving motive, INT = Purchase intention, NOF = Number of followers.

4.5. Post-hoc analysis: Exploring the moderating role of gender through multigroup analysis

Available evidence indicates that consumption behaviors and evaluative judgements are gender-dependent (Holbrook, 1986). Hence, Bergvist and Zhou (2016) argued that gender difference should be explored in the influencer context. For instance, Bush, Martin, and Bush (2004) revealed that celebrity role models exert greater influence on female compared to male teenagers. In addition, several studies have identified that men and women use media differently in addressing their emotional needs, and women tend to develop stronger parasocial relationships with media figures than do men (Lather & Moyer-Guse, 2011; Wang, Fink, & Cai, 2008). However, men exhibit a greater level of celebrity worship (McCutcheon, Lange, & Houran, 2002). Thus, it is reasonable to assume that gender may affect the extent to which consumers develop and rely upon parasocial relationships, as well as how they perceive endorser motives. In line with these arguments, we explored the potential observed heterogeneity by comparing the results yielded by the proposed model when applied to male and female participants separately.

First, we followed the approach adopted by Matthews (2018) and randomly withdrew respondents from the larger subgroup (females) to ensure comparable group size. Second, adhering to Henseler, Ringle, and Sarstedt (2016) suggestion, we assessed the measurement invariance for gender using the MICOM procedure. The configural invariance was established using the same setup (identical indicators, data treatment, and algorithm settings) in model estimation for both male and female sub-groups. As shown in Table 3, compositional invariance was established but the results indicated significant differences in means and variances for a few constructs, suggesting partial measurement invariance. Therefore, the execution of PLS-MGA for structural path comparison across groups was allowed (Henseler et al., 2016). As shown in Table 4, the PLS-MGA results revealed significant group differences in the effects of prestige on parasocial relationships, which were stronger for males. Similarly, the effect of perceived self-serving motives on purchase intention was stronger for male participants.

5. Discussion

The rise of social media influencers is changing the landscape of influencer endorsement. As they exert powerful clout on their followers, brand marketers are increasingly relying on social media influencers as endorsers of their products and services. Despite being heralded as one of the most widely adopted promotional strategies, social media influencer marketing has been given scant attention in academic literature, where focus is mainly on traditional celebrity endorsements (Ki & Kim, 2019). This gap presents a critical issue for marketers, as lacking solid understanding of how social media influencer marketing is managed can impede the endorsement effectiveness. Towards this end, we developed a model to examine the impact of social media influencers' influence

attempts on several important yet overlooked downstream outcomes (i.e., parasocial relationships, perceived self-serving motives, and purchase intention).

In the present study, we extended the applicability of influence theory (Scheer & Stern, 1992) to digital marketing context and explored the dynamic interactions between social media influencers and consumers. We revealed that social media influencers' content as a form of influence attempt is capable of fostering the illusionary intimacy between influencers and consumers. Our findings further revealed that the greater the extent to which a consumer perceives a social media influencer's social media content as visually attractive, displaying sense of prestige, and exhibiting expertise, the more likely it is that a parasocial relationship will be established. These findings expand upon the results yielded by prior studies indicating that intensity of social media interactions is a driver of parasocial relationships with celebrities (Aw & Labrecque, 2020; Chung & Cho, 2017) by identifying key social media content qualities in developing parasocial relationships.

Moreover, our post-hoc analysis indicates that number of followers exerts negative influence on parasocial relationships, thus countering the prevalent view that popularity is commensurate with likability (De Veirman et al., 2017; Jin & Phua, 2014). We contend that parasocial relationships followers form with social media influencers differ from those involving traditional celebrities. As social media influencers are "grass-roots" celebrities, they engender a sense of closeness and relatedness which tends to dissipate as influencers amass a significant number of followers (Tafesse & Wood, 2021). This argument is in line with Djafarova and Rushworth's (2017), finding that consumers perceive lower-end influencers with modest number of followers as comparatively more trustful and personally relevant. The null effects of number of followers we found in our study on the perception of endorser motives as self-serving and consumer purchase intentions concur with the arguments put forth by Yuan, Moon, Kim, and Wang (2019), implying that indication of popularity alone does not offer sufficient product/brand information to aid purchase decisions.

Another important and novel finding that has emerged from our study is the moderating effect of self-discrepancy in the relationship between influence attempts (i.e., attractiveness and prestige) and parasocial relationships. We revealed that influence attempts have stronger impacts on parasocial relationships when consumers exhibit low self-discrepancy, thus countering our initial hypothesis. This finding suggests that low self-discrepancy drives consumers to appropriate and assimilate the attractiveness and prestige cues exhibited in social media influencers' content to a greater extent, whereby the unexpected direction of moderating effects could be explained by the assimilation and contrast theory (Mussweiler & Strack, 2000). The theory argues that the assimilation effect is more likely to occur when consumers perceive their ideal self as attainable (Malär et al., 2018). According to Malär et al. (2018), consumers who exhibit a high degree of self-discrepancy feel far removed from their ideal self, especially that related to agentic ideals such as beauty and status, which they feel would be impossible to

achieve (Sheldon & Cooper, 2008). Hence, they are less likely to assimilate attractiveness and prestige cues in developing relationships with social media influencers.

The assumption that influencer endorsement can induce consumers' belief that the influencer shares traits with the products or likes the products is overly simplistic. This is because consumers are aware of persuasion tactics used in marketing, and are likely to question the motives of such communication efforts (Arsena, Silvera, & Pandelaere, 2014; Forehand & Grier, 2003). Specifically, consumers are mindful of the financial compensation influencers receive for their endorsements and are skeptical of their intentions. We contribute to the influencer endorsement literature by showing that forming parasocial relationships could reduce the likelihood that influencers' motives will be perceived as self-serving, thus increasing the endorsement effectiveness. Our findings evidenced that, just as in real friendships, consumers are likely to align their attitudes with those of the social media influencers with whom they have parasocial relationships. The information processing theory contends that emotional connections can effectively augment the processing of advertisement and brand messages (MacInnis & Jaworski, 1989). Parasocial relationships that are built upon cumulative information disclosure and in-depth understanding fortify the perceived authenticity while discounting the potential negative information pertaining to the social media influencer, thereby creating a positive bias in the evaluation of endorser motives, which eventually leads to greater purchase intention.

Our exploratory analysis yielded two interesting findings regarding the moderating effect of gender, indicating that the effect of prestige on parasocial relationships as well as perceived self-serving motive on purchase intention is stronger for males. This is to be expected, as gender influences social interactions, whereby men are more likely than women to pursue respect and social standing (Gefen & Straub, 1997). According to Cross and Madson (1997), they are also more prone to acting according to patterns of behavior that elevate personal status. Hence, prestige quality as manifested in the social media influencers' content would be more relevant in fostering the parasocial relationships for men. In addition, as women are in general more generous, kind, and socially-oriented (Eagly & Crowley, 1986; Kashdan, Mishra, Breen, & Froh, 2009), they are more likely to tolerate social media influencers' self-serving motives, especially if they perceive them as close friends. Moreover, women tend to ponder on their decisions longer than men do (Meyers-Levy & Maheswaran, 1991). As a result, their attitudes toward an endorsed product or service are less affected by their perception of influencers' motives, as they would consider other aspects, such as the actual product attributes and their relationships with the influencers. Hence, the path between self-serving motive and purchase intention is weaker for women.

5.1. Theoretical implications

The theoretical contributions of this study stem from the exploration of heretofore-untested mechanism that is salient to perceived endorser motives and the subsequent endorsement outcome (i.e., purchase intention). Even though authors of prior studies have raised concern over the imperilment of social media influencers' endorsing motive when they partner with brands (Audrezet et al., 2020; Shan et al., 2019), little research has been conducted to understand how social media influencers can manage consumers' inference of motive. Our study contributes to this research strand by shedding light on the captivating role of parasocial relationships as social media influencers' tool for counteracting the consumers' perception of their endorsement motives as self-serving. This finding adds to the existing social media influencer literature that primarily focuses on the impact of parasocial relationships on brand-related outcomes (e.g., purchase intention and product interest) (Fariyar et al., 2020; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020; Yuan & Lou, 2020). Second, current social media influencer research as a part of which antecedents of parasocial relationships are explored has been

limited to the role of influencer traits, including credibility and attractiveness (Sokolova & Kefi, 2020; Yuan & Lou, 2020), thus typically overlooking the importance of content-driven traits (Casaló et al., 2020; Ki et al., 2020). This study has extended the theoretical body of knowledge by unveiling the influence attempts (i.e., attractiveness, prestige, and expertise) as tantamount in explaining parasocial relationships, thereby offering an alternative view for influencer-fan relationship management. Moreover, by showcasing that negative and null impacts number of followers exerts on the outcome variables (i.e., parasocial relationships, self-serving motive, and purchase intention), the present study offers an alternative view to that purported in the current literature which seems to overstate the prominence of popularity as an influencer marketing consideration.

Third, the present study unpacks the moderating mechanisms underpinning the meaning assimilation and appropriation by consumers from external information sources. The significant moderating effect of self-discrepancy that emerged from our analyses suggests that not all influence attempts by social media influencers are equally perceived and harnessed in cultivating parasocial relationships, thereby offering a more nuanced perspective than that typically conveyed by influencer literature based on the assumption of direct linear effects of self-concept appraisal on endorsement outcomes. Lastly, the findings yield by our post-hoc analysis indicate that the impacts of influence attempts as well as perceived self-serving motives are gender-dependent, challenging the validity of the homogeneous lens applied in prior social media influencer research. The examination of self-concept appraisal (i.e., self-discrepancy) and gender corroborates Hudders, De Jans, and De Veirman (2020) assertion that follower/fan characteristics play an important role in social media influencer marketing, and require further research.

5.2. Practical implications

From a managerial standpoint, our findings present several important implications for marketing practitioners. In the current market flooded by influencer endorsement, consumers are more aware of the persuasion tactics employed by brands and are more skeptical of the motives behind influencers' endorsements. Hence, brand marketers and endorsers are striving to reduce attribution of self-serving motive. The present study highlights the importance of quality of influencer-fan relationships in endorser selection, given that the general social media influencer metrics, such as total number of fans and followers, may not directly translate into audiences' attitudes (Ki & Kim, 2019). Consequently, instead of selecting social media influencers based on their physical appearance, brand marketers should choose those who have or are able to generate high parasocial relationships with followers through relationship-oriented metrics (e.g., sentiment) (Arora, Bansal, Kandpal, Aswani, & Dwivedi, 2019), to induce positive responses towards the endorsement.

We further advocate that influencer marketing should focus on activating parasocial relationships. To this end, social media influencers need to engage in a more interactive manner (e.g., respond to comments) with their followers through social media (Aw & Labrecque, 2020; Chung & Cho, 2017). More importantly, we suggest that brand marketers and social media influencers need to be mindful in crafting their content, as it is their main bridge of communication with fans. Particularly, they could leverage on social media content analysis to identify and learn from the posts that best convey the qualities of attractiveness, prestige, and expertise in order to strengthen parasocial relationships. Due to the greater importance of attractiveness attributes relative to prestige and expertise, understanding how to incorporate this element into social media content is paramount. For example, hypothetically, attractive content may embody features such as forms (e.g., vlog), facial expressions (e.g., smile), gaze direction (gaze at the camera), camera distance (full-body), and creative language. It is also worth noting that number of followers cannot be a sole metric for successful

Table A1
Measurement items.

Attractiveness (Ki & Kim, 2019)
I find (SMI's name)'s social media contents good-looking.
I find (SMI's name)'s social media contents attractive.
I find (SMI's name)'s social media contents visually appealing.
Prestige (Ki & Kim, 2019)
I find that (SMI's name)'s social media contents are prestigious.
I find that (SMI's name)'s social media contents are upscale.
I find that (SMI's name)'s social media contents have high status.
Expertise (Ki & Kim, 2019)
When looking at (SMI's name)'s social media contents, I find s/he is experienced.
When looking at (SMI's name)'s social media contents, I find s/he is an expert.
When looking at (SMI's name)'s social media contents, I find s/he is qualified.
Parasocial relationships (Chung & Cho, 2017)
(SMI's name) makes me feel comfortable, as if I am with a friend.
I would like to have a friendly chat with (SMI's name).
If (SMI's name) were not a famous person, we would have been good friends.
I think I understand (SMI's name) quite well.
When (SMI's name) behaves in a certain way, I know the reasons for his/her behavior.
I can feel (SMI's name)'s emotions in certain situations.
(SMI's name) seems to understand the kinds of things I want to know.
(SMI's name) reminds me of myself.
I can identify with (SMI's name).
Perceived self-serving motive (Rifon et al., 2004)
(SMI's name) recommends brands because ultimately he/she care about his/her followers. (Reverse-coded)
(SMI's name) is not genuinely concerned for the welfare of his/her followers.
(SMI's name) cares about getting useful information to his/her followers. (Reverse-coded)
(SMI's name) recommends brands to persuade me to buy his/her products
(SMI's name) recommends brands because he/she ultimately only care about his/her profits.
(SMI's name) recommends brands to create a positive self-image.
Purchase intention (Ki & Kim, 2019)
In the future, I am likely to try one of the same services that (SMI's name) endorsed or posted on social media.
In the future, I am likely to try one of the same products that (SMI's name) endorsed or posted on social media.
In the future, I am likely to try one of the same brands that (SMI's name) endorsed or posted on social media.
Self-concepts (Sirgy et al., 1997)
The personality of (SMI's name) is consistent with how I see myself.
The personality of (SMI's name) is a mirror image of me.
The personality of (SMI's name) is consistent with how I would like to be.
The personality of (SMI's name) is a mirror image of the person I would like to be.

influencer marketing. As was shown in our study, huge number of followers hinders parasocial relationship development and follower engagement. Thus, other qualities social media influencers possess, such as ability to create and engage with active communities, should weigh more in endorser selection criteria (Reinikainen et al., 2020).

Furthermore, when using the influence attempt of prestige, target market must be determined to obtain optimal results, as male and female consumers respond differently towards such attempts. Social media influencers who mainly attract female followers might want to emphasize attractive instead of prestige-based content to promote parasocial relationships with their fans. In addition, social media influencers should limit their self-branding and self-promotion as this may induce large self-discrepancy among their followers and could undermine their influence efforts and desired intent. Unlike traditional mainstream celebrities, social media influencers cannot rely on distancing strategies to create an aura of mystique and superiority, as their status depends on connections with others. A more well-balanced self-presentation approach that involves self-disclosure as well as the conveyance of commonality and ordinariness is deemed more suitable in strengthening

the power of influence attempts for parasocial relationship development (Chung & Cho, 2017; Pöyry et al., 2019).

6. Limitations and future research directions

First, the present study employed self-report measures in assessing consumers' perception of social media influencers' content characteristics (i.e., attractiveness, prestige, and expertise), which could introduce bias. For instance, social media influencers have different posting preferences in terms of content type (videos, photos, and texts), and videos could be more effective and appealing than picture and text content in conveying information via social media. Therefore, future studies could employ critical discourse analysis or netnography approach to analyze words, images, and videos used in postings to further enhance the findings reported here. Second, despite being valid and enriching, the three principal traits of influence attempts in focus of the present study may not fully capture all pertinent social media content characteristics. Nonetheless, the model developed as a part of this study can serve as a starting point towards a broader and holistic understanding of parasocial relationships and can be refined in future studies. Third, the present study is placed in a general social media context. In order to enrich the theoretical and practical understanding of the phenomena examined here, authors of future studies could compare the effects of different social media platforms, as they have been shown to impact influencer-follower interactions and the formation of parasocial relationships differently. Lastly, it would also be fruitful to investigate the different types of social media influencers, such as megainfluencers, macroinfluencers, and microinfluencers, to establish whether consumers rely on the same content characteristics when pursuing parasocial relationships with different types of influencers, and whether the influencer type impacts followers' perception of endorsement motives.

Appendix A

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